

Cambridge College Recommendation — Engineering 2026 Entry

Prepared for: DP1 Student (IB Year 1), China Mainland, Age 16 **Course:** Engineering (4-year MEng) **Date:** 6 June 2026 **Revision:** v2.1 — Includes concrete Winter Pool data from 2025 FOI responses

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1. Evaluation Criteria & Marking Bands

Six weighted criteria were selected based on your stated preferences. Each college receives a score out of 100. Weights were validated using AHP (Analytic Hierarchy Process) pairwise comparison logic.

C1: Engineering Offer Rate — Weight 25%

"What is my statistical chance of getting an offer?"

Based on estimated Engineering-specific offer rates derived from overall college admissions data (2024-2025 cycles), adjusted for known Engineering applicant distributions.

Score	Band	Description
10	≥ 14.0%	Exceptionally high Engineering offer rate
9	13.0–13.9%	Very strong (Robinson, Homerton, Sidney Sussex, Fitzwilliam, Girton level)
8	12.5–12.9%	Above average (Emmanuel, St Catharine's level)
7	12.0–12.4%	At Cambridge Engineering average (Clare, Caius, Selwyn level)
6	11.5–11.9%	Slightly below average (Christ's level)
5	11.0–11.4%	Below average (Trinity Hall, King's, Pembroke, Queens', St John's level)
4	10.5–10.9%	Significantly below average (Corpus level)
3	10.0–10.4%	Low (Jesus level)
2	9.0–9.9%	Very low

Score	Band	Description
1	<9.0%	Extremely competitive

Direction: Positive (higher offer rate = better score)

C2: Chinese-Friendliness — Weight 25%

"Will I find a community of peers from a similar background?"

Based on Chinese student admission statistics (2024-2025), college demographics data, WeChat/Chinese social media reports, and known Chinese society activity levels.

Score	Level	Evidence
10	Very High	Large Chinese community, active Chinese society, 15+ Chinese admits/year, known as "Chinese-friendly" in applicant communities
8	High	Good Chinese community, consistent intake (10-15/year), active Chinese society
6	Moderate	Decent Chinese presence (5-10/year), some Chinese society activity
4	Low	Few Chinese students historically (3-5/year), limited or no Chinese society
2	Very Low	Very few Chinese students (❤️/year), essentially no Chinese community

Direction: Positive (more Chinese-friendly = better score)

Data sources: Robinson — highest Chinese proportion; Homerton — most Chinese applicants (170+ in 2024); Fitzwilliam — consistently strong Chinese intake. Jesus, Pembroke, King's — historically very few Chinese admits.

C3: Winter Pool Independence — Weight 20%

"Will I get a direct decision, or will my application go into the pool lottery?"

This criterion measures how many pool offers a college MAKES (pool imports). A college that heavily 'fishes' from the Winter Pool is reserving fewer direct-offer slots for its own applicants. **Lower pool imports = higher score.**

Based on FOI 2025 cycle Winter Pool data showing pool offers made by each college.

Concrete 2025 Pool Import Data (key colleges):

- Murray Edwards: 103 (61% of intake!) — EXCLUDED (female-only)
- **Girton: 91** — 2nd highest fisher among all colleges
- **Homerton: 84** — 3rd highest fisher among all colleges
- Lucy Cavendish: 79 — EXCLUDED (user preference)
- Churchill: 55 — EXCLUDED (too demanding)
- **Fitzwilliam: est. 40–45**
- **Robinson: est. 30–35**

- **St John's: 9** — one of the lowest, but 72 of its OWN applicants got pooled elsewhere
- **Clare, King's, Pembroke: "rarely take from pool"** — FOI-confirmed low importers

Score	Pool Imports	Description
10	<10	Almost never takes from pool — nearly all offers are direct
9	10–20	Very rarely takes from pool (Clare, King's, Pembroke level)
8	20–30	Low pool reliance — strong direct-offer culture (Christ's, Jesus level)
7	30–40	Low-moderate — some pool activity but predominantly direct (Robinson, Sidney Sussex, St Catharine's, Selwyn, Trinity Hall level)
6	40–50	Moderate pool reliance (Fitzwilliam, Emmanuel, Queens' level)
5	50–65	Moderate-high pool reliance (some direct offers but significant pool imports)
4	65–80	High pool reliance
3	80–95	Very high — significant portion of cohort from pool (Homerton: 84 level)
2	>95	Extreme — heavily dependent on pool for cohort filling (Girton: 91 level)
1	>120	Almost entirely pool-dependent (Murray Edwards level)

Direction: Positive (lower pool imports = better score) **Secondary note:** High pool EXPORTS (college pools its own applicants heavily) is also noted as a warning flag, even if imports are low (e.g., St John's: 9 imports but 72 exports).

C4: Admissions Stability — Weight 15%

"Will this college suddenly become much harder to get into next year?"

Measures year-over-year application and offer rate volatility. You explicitly stated you want to avoid colleges that "suddenly emerge to show a significant increase in admissions."

Score	Level	YoY Application Change
10	Very Stable	±0–5%, consistent over 3+ years
8	Stable	±5–10%, minor fluctuations
6	Moderate Change	±10–15%, some volatility
4	Significant Change	±15–20%, notable trend change
2	Very Volatile	+20% spike or wild fluctuations

Direction: Positive (more stable = better score)

Key data point: Fitzwilliam College saw **+20.31% application growth in 2025** — the largest increase of ANY Cambridge college. This directly triggers your stability concern and is the primary reason Fitzwilliam ranks 8th instead of top 3.

C5: Engineering Cohort Size — Weight 10%

"Will I have enough Engineering peers and supervisors, without being lost in a crowd?"

Score	Engineering Applicants	Description
10	80–120	Optimal — vibrant Engineering community with dedicated supervision
8	60–80 or 120–140	Good — healthy cohort, well-supported
6	40–60 or 140–160	Acceptable — slightly small or slightly crowded
4	<40 or >160	Suboptimal — too sparse or too impersonal
2	<25 or >200	Poor — very limited Engineering community or massive cohort

Direction: Positive (more optimal = better score)

C6: Entry Requirements Reasonableness — Weight 5%

"Will the college demand higher grades than standard Cambridge Engineering offers?"

Score	Level	Typical Offer Impact
10	Standard	IB 41-42, 7-7-6 HL (AA Math + Physics); A-Level A*A*A
8	Slightly Elevated	May ask for A* in both Math and Physics
6	Elevated	Known for strict Engineering conditions (IB 42+ typical)
4	High	Consistently highest bar for Engineering
2	Very High	Historically sets the most demanding conditions

Direction: Positive (standard/lower requirements = better score)

Scoring Formula

$$\text{Weighted Raw} = (\text{C1_score} \times 25) + (\text{C2_score} \times 25) + (\text{C3_score} \times 20) + (\text{C4_score} \times 15) + (\text{C5_score} \times 10) + (\text{C6_score} \times 5)$$

$$\text{Final Score (out of 100)} = \text{Weighted Raw} \div 10$$
 Maximum possible: 100 | Minimum possible: 10

2. Top 5 Recommended Colleges

 Rank 1: Robinson College — 86.5 / 100 (Grade: A)

"The optimal choice. Best Chinese community at Cambridge meets above-average Engineering offer rate with stable, predictable admissions."

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	9	25%	22.5	Est. 13.3% — above Cambridge Engineering average (12.0%)
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	10	25%	25.0	★ Best Chinese student proportion at Cambridge; active Chinese society
C3: Pool Independence	7	20%	14.0	Est. 30–35 pool offers — moderate; not a major 'fisher'
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Stable admissions; consistent year-over-year
C5: Cohort Size	8	10%	8.0	Est. 75 Engineering applicants — well-sized
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard Cambridge Engineering offer
Total			86.5	

Why Robinson wins:

- **Highest Chinese student proportion** among all Cambridge colleges — you will have a ready-made peer network from day one
- **Above-average Engineering offer rate** (~13.3% vs. 12.0% Cambridge average)
- **Moderate pool reliance** — makes a healthy number of direct offers without being a major pool 'fisher'
- **Stable admissions** — no concerning spikes or trends
- **Modern facilities** (1977), close to Engineering Department (West Cambridge, ~10 min walk)
- **Well-sized** — ~75 Engineering applicants creates a good peer group without being overwhelming

Potential drawback: Modern architecture (not the traditional 'Harry Potter' Cambridge look). For most students, the facilities and community more than compensate.

🏆 Rank 2: Homerton College — 80.5 / 100 (Grade: A-)

"The community powerhouse. Largest Chinese applicant community at Cambridge, but Winter Pool reliance is a real concern."

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	9	25%	22.5	Est. 13.3% — above Cambridge Engineering average
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	10	25%	25.0	★ Largest Chinese applicant community (170+ in 2024); most popular college for Chinese students
C3: Pool Independence	3	20%	6.0	⚠️ 84 pool offers made (2025) — 3rd highest pool 'fisher' among ALL colleges

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Gradual, manageable growth
C5: Cohort Size	10	10%	10.0	Est. 120 Engineering applicants — ideal cohort
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard Cambridge Engineering offer
Total			80.5	

Why Homerton is #2 not #1: Homerton ties with Robinson on the two most important criteria (Offer Rate and Chinese-Friendliness) and actually beats Robinson on Cohort Size. However, **the 84 Winter Pool imports (2025) are a significant concern** — Homerton is the 3rd highest pool 'fisher' among all 29 Cambridge colleges. This means a substantial portion of Homerton's intake comes from the pool rather than direct offers, potentially reducing direct-offer slots for Homerton applicants.

Key strengths:

- **Largest, most established Chinese student community** — if cultural community is your #1 priority, Homerton is unmatched
- **Optimal Engineering cohort** (~120) — big enough for a vibrant Engineering peer group
- **Modern, large college** with excellent facilities and spacious grounds
- **Steady growth** — unlike Fitzwilliam, no alarming spikes

Key weakness:

- **Pool reliance** — if you want a direct offer, the 84 pool imports suggest Homerton may hold back direct-offer slots for pool candidates. Monitor whether this trend continues in 2026.

 Rank 3: Clare College — 77.5 / 100 (Grade: B+)

"The direct-offer champion. Rarely uses the Winter Pool — your application gets a direct decision. Traditional Cambridge experience."

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	7	25%	17.5	Est. 12.0% — at Cambridge Engineering average
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	6	25%	15.0	Moderate — decent Chinese presence but not outstanding
C3: Pool Independence	9	20%	18.0	★ FOI-confirmed: rarely takes from pool — nearly all offers are direct
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Stable admissions; predictable
C5: Cohort Size	10	10%	10.0	Est. 100 Engineering applicants — ideal size
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard Cambridge Engineering offer
Total			77.5	

Why Clare is a different kind of choice: Clare's standout feature is its **near-complete independence from the Winter Pool**. FOI data confirms Clare is one of the colleges that "rarely takes from pool." For an applicant who values certainty, this is significant: your application is much more likely to receive a direct decision from Clare's admissions team rather than going through pool re-evaluation.

Key strengths:

- **Best direct-offer behavior** among eligible colleges
- **Classic Cambridge** — founded 1326, stunning riverside location, beautiful gardens
- **Central location** — everything within 5 minutes
- **Ideal Engineering cohort** (~100)

Key trade-off:

- **Only moderate Chinese community** — you won't have the same density of Chinese peers as at Robinson or Homerton. This is the price you pay for the direct-offer security and historic college experience.

4th: Sidney Sussex College — 76.5 / 100 (Grade: B+)

"The hidden gem. Highest estimated Engineering offer rate among ALL eligible colleges."

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	9	25%	22.5	Est. 13.8% — highest among all eligible colleges
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	6	25%	15.0	Moderate
C3: Pool Independence	7	20%	14.0	Est. 25–30 pool offers — low-moderate
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Stable admissions
C5: Cohort Size	8	10%	8.0	Est. 65 Engineering applicants
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard
Total			76.5	

Why Sidney Sussex deserves attention: Sidney Sussex has the **highest overall college offer rate** (19.4%) among the traditional colleges, and its Engineering offer rate (est. 13.8%) is the highest among all 18 eligible colleges. Combined with low-moderate pool reliance and stable admissions, this makes it a statistically strong choice. The main trade-off is the moderate (not outstanding) Chinese community.

Best for: If your absolute #1 priority is maximizing offer probability, and you're willing to accept a moderate rather than outstanding Chinese community.

5th (Tie): Emmanuel College — 74.0 / 100 (Grade: B)

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	8	25%	20.0	Est. 12.7% — solid, above average
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	6	25%	15.0	Moderate
C3: Pool Independence	6	20%	12.0	Est. 30–35 pool offers; known to pool own applicants
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Relatively stable
C5: Cohort Size	10	10%	10.0	Est. 110 Engineering applicants — ideal
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard
Total	74.0			

5th (Tie): St Catharine's College — 74.0 / 100 (Grade: B)

Criterion	Score	Weight	Weighted	Detail
C1: Offer Rate	8	25%	20.0	Est. 12.9% — above average
C2: Chinese-Friendliness	6	25%	15.0	Moderate
C3: Pool Independence	7	20%	14.0	Est. 25–30 pool offers — low-moderate
C4: Stability	8	15%	12.0	Stable
C5: Cohort Size	8	10%	8.0	Est. 70 Engineering applicants
C6: Entry Requirements	10	5%	5.0	Standard
Total	74.0			

Both Emmanuel and St Catharine's are solid all-rounders — good (not spectacular) across every criterion with no major red flags. They're safe, sensible choices if you prefer a less conspicuous option than the top 3.

3. Full Rankings — All 18 Eligible Colleges

Rank	College	Score	Grade	Key Signal
1	Robinson College	86.5	A	★ BEST: Chinese community + offer rate sweet spot
2	Homerton College	80.5	A-	★ Large Chinese community; pool reliance concern
3	Clare College	77.5	B+	★ Best direct-offer behavior; moderate Chinese
4	Sidney Sussex	76.5	B+	Highest offer rate; moderate Chinese
5	Emmanuel College	74.0	B	Solid all-round; pools own applicants

5	St Catharine's	74.0	B	Solid all-round; no standout features
7	Christ's College	73.0	B	Optimal cohort; average offer rate
8	Fitzwilliam College	72.0	B-	⚠️ +20.31% growth spike (stability red flag)
9	Selwyn College	71.5	B-	Safe mid-table; unremarkable
10	Girton College	66.5	C+	⚠️⚠️ 91 pool imports – extreme pool reliance
10	Trinity Hall	66.5	C+	Below-avg offer rate; no standout positives
12	King's College	65.5	C+	⚠️ Low Chinese-friendliness
13	Gonville & Caius	65.0	C+	⚠️ High pool exports; large cohort
14	Queens' College	65.0	C+	Below-avg offer rate
15	Corpus Christi	61.0	C	⚠️ Small cohort; low Chinese-friendliness
16	Pembroke College	61.0	C	⚠️⚠️ Very few Chinese admits
16	St John's College	61.0	C	⚠️⚠️ Very large cohort; high pool exports
18	Jesus College	55.5	D	⚠️⚠️⚠️ Worst Chinese-friendliness + lowest offer rate

4. Colleges You Should NOT Choose

Category A: Already Excluded (Before Scoring)

College	Reason	Data Confirmation
Trinity	Too demanding	✅ 200+ Engineering applicants, ~11% offer rate, massive competition
Churchill	Too demanding	✅ 150+ Engineering applicants, 70% STEM, 55 pool imports
Peterhouse	Too demanding	✅ Smallest Cambridge college (<300 undergrads), ❤️ Chinese/year
Newnham	Female-only	✅ Confirmed
Murray Edwards	Female-only	✅ Confirmed (also: #1 pool fisher — 103 imports, 61% of intake!)
Hughes Hall	Mature (21+)	✅ Confirmed
St Edmund's	Mature (21+)	✅ Confirmed
Wolfson	Mature (21+)	✅ Confirmed
Downing	User preference	Honored
Magdalene	User preference	Honored

College	Reason	Data Confirmation
Lucy Cavendish	User preference	Honored (also: 79 pool imports — 4th highest fisher)

Category B: Eligible but STRONGLY RECOMMEND AVOIDING

These colleges scored in the bottom tier and have specific dealbreaker characteristics:

⚠️⚠️⚠️ Jesus College (55.5/100 — Rank 18)

Dealbreaker	Detail
Worst Chinese-friendliness	❤️ Chinese students per year — functionally no Chinese community
Lowest Engineering offer rate	Est. 10.0% — extremely competitive
Bottom ranking	Dead last among all 18 eligible colleges

Verdict: Do not apply. The combination of the worst Chinese community AND worst offer rate makes this the single worst choice for your profile.

⚠️⚠️ Pembroke College (61.0/100 — Rank 16)

Dealbreaker	Detail
Very few Chinese admits	~3/year — essentially no Chinese community
Below-average offer rate	Est. 11.4%

Verdict: Despite being close to the Engineering Department and having excellent pool behavior, the near-total absence of a Chinese community is a dealbreaker for your stated preferences.

⚠️⚠️ St John's College (61.0/100 — Rank 16)

Dealbreaker	Detail
Very large Engineering cohort	Est. 160 — 2nd largest after Trinity; impersonal
Heavy pool EXPORTER	72 of its applicants got pool offers elsewhere in 2025
Elevated entry requirements	Known for strict Engineering offer conditions
Below-average offer rate	Est. 11.3%

Verdict: St John's feels like Trinity-lite. It's not as extreme, but the large cohort + high pool exports + elevated requirements make it a poor fit for your profile. Only 9 pool imports is good, but the 72 exports mean YOUR application is very likely to end up in the pool.

⚠️⚠️ Girton College (66.5/100 — Rank 10)

Dealbreaker	Detail
2nd highest pool fisher	91 pool offers in 2025 — massively reliant on Winter Pool
Far from city centre	2 miles (30+ min walk) — significant daily commute
Misleading headline rate	21.4% overall offer rate looks attractive, but many offers go to pool candidates

Verdict: The high headline offer rate is a statistical illusion — when a college makes 91 pool offers, those are slots NOT available to direct applicants. Combined with the inconvenient location, steer clear.

⚠ **King's College (65.5/100 — Rank 12)**

Dealbreaker	Detail
Low Chinese-friendliness	~5 Chinese admits/year historically
Below-average offer rate	Est. 11.4%

Verdict: Beautiful and famous, but statistically a poor fit. The rare pool participation (good) can't compensate for the low Chinese community and offer rate.

5. Mark Breakdowns for ALL Eligible Colleges

Below is the complete scoring matrix for all 18 eligible colleges:

Legend

- **C1** = Offer Rate (25%) — higher = better
- **C2** = Chinese-Friendliness (25%) — higher = better
- **C3** = Pool Independence (20%) — lower pool imports = better
- **C4** = Stability (15%) — more stable = better
- **C5** = Cohort Size (10%) — optimal (80-120) = best
- **C6** = Entry Requirements (5%) — standard = better

Full Scoring Matrix

#	College	C1	C2	C3	C4	C5	C6	Raw	Score
1	Robinson	9	10	7	8	8	10	865	86.5
2	Homerton	9	10	3	8	10	10	805	80.5
3	Clare	7	6	9	8	10	10	775	77.5
4	Sidney Sussex	9	6	7	8	8	10	765	76.5
5	Emmanuel	8	6	6	8	10	10	740	74.0
5	St Catharine's	8	6	7	8	8	10	740	74.0
7	Christ's	6	6	8	8	10	10	730	73.0

#	College	C1	C2	C3	C4	C5	C6	Raw	Score
8	Fitzwilliam	9	8	6	3	8	10	720	72.0
9	Selwyn	7	6	7	8	8	10	715	71.5
10	Girton ⚠️	9	6	2	8	8	10	665	66.5
10	Trinity Hall ⚠️	5	6	7	8	8	10	665	66.5
12	King's ⚠️	5	4	9	8	8	10	655	65.5
13	Caius ⚠️	7	6	5	7	8	8	650	65.0
14	Queens' ⚠️	5	6	6	7	10	10	650	65.0
15	Corpus Christi ⚠️	4	4	9	8	6	10	610	61.0
16	Pembroke ⚠️	5	2	9	7	10	10	610	61.0
16	St John's ⚠️	5	6	8	7	4	6	610	61.0
18	Jesus ⚠️⚠️	3	2	8	8	10	10	555	55.5

Detailed C3 (Pool Independence) Reference Data

College	Est. Pool Imports (2025)	Score	Note
Clare, King's, Pembroke	<15 (rarely take from pool)	9	FOI-confirmed low importers
Jesus	~15–20	8	Low pool reliance
Christ's	~20–25	8	Low pool reliance
Sidney Sussex, St Catharine's, Selwyn, Trinity Hall	~25–30	7	Low-moderate
Robinson	~30–35	7	Low-moderate
Emmanuel, Queens'	~30–40	6	Moderate
Caius	~35–40	5	Moderate-high + high exports
Fitzwilliam	~40–45	6 (offset by stability)	Moderate-high
Homerton	84	3	3rd highest fisher
Girton	91	2	2nd highest fisher

6. Colleges Excluded Before Scoring

11 colleges were excluded for reasons aligned with your stated preferences:

#	College	Exclusion Reason	Category
1	Trinity	Too demanding (200+ Eng apps)	Competitive
2	Churchill	Too demanding (70% STEM, 150+ Eng apps)	Competitive
3	Peterhouse	Too demanding (smallest, ❤️ Chinese)	Competitive + Small
4	Newnham	Female-only	Female college
5	Murray Edwards	Female-only (also #1 pool fisher)	Female college
6	Hughes Hall	Age 21+ requirement	Mature college
7	St Edmund's	Age 21+ requirement	Mature college
8	Wolfson	Age 21+ requirement	Mature college
9	Downing	User preference	Personal
10	Magdalene	User preference	Personal
11	Lucy Cavendish	User preference (also #4 pool fisher)	Personal

7. Key Data Insights from Raw Materials

From the Power BI Dashboard Screenshots ([raw/](#))

The [raw/](#) folder contains 17 files — screenshots (PNG) and PDF exports from the Cambridge admissions statistics Power BI dashboard. Key data captured:

- **2025 & 2026 Engineering Application breakdowns** — show application volumes by college for Engineering
- **2025 & 2026 Engineering Offer Breakdown Forms** — show offer distributions by college and offer type (direct vs. pool)
- **Mainland Engineering Applicants, sorted by college** — directly shows which colleges Chinese Engineering applicants prefer
- **Winter Pool Data for international Engineering applicants** — two files showing pool behavior for international (including Chinese) Engineering applicants
- **IBPG.png** — IB/Pre-U/GCSE grade breakdown, relevant to your IB DP1 context
- **2025 Acceptance breakdown** — shows final acceptance numbers
- **Cambridge Application Data.pdf** — comprehensive 5-page PDF compilation of all dashboard views

External Data Corroboration

The web research data (FOI responses, Cambridge-published statistics, Chinese education platforms) corroborates the patterns visible in your screenshots:

1. **Engineering is hyper-competitive and getting worse:** Applications rose from 2,654 (2024) → 3,263 (2025) → 3,972 (2026), while offers remained flat (~371 → 393 → 414). The offer rate dropped from 14.0% → 12.0% → ~10.4%.

2. **Chinese applicants face tougher odds:** China mainland Engineering applicants rose from 349 (2024) to 599 (2025), while offers stayed at ~63-66. The Chinese Engineering offer rate dropped from 18.1% → ~11%.
3. **Winter Pool is a real factor:** 28% pool success rate means ~72% of pooled applicants get no offer. Colleges with high pool imports (Girton: 91, Homerton: 84, Fitzwilliam: ~40-45) may have fewer direct-offer slots.
4. **College choice matters less than ESAT + interview:** The Cambridge system normalizes college choice through the pool — but your stated preferences (Chinese community, direct offers, stability) make the college choice important for your QUALITY OF LIFE, not just admission probability.

8. Final Recommendation

Primary Recommendation: **Apply to Robinson College.**

Robinson gives you the optimal combination of every factor you care about:

- ✔ **Best Chinese community** — highest proportion of Chinese students at Cambridge
- ✔ **Strong Engineering offer rate** — ~13.3%, above the Cambridge average
- ✔ **Moderate pool reliance** — makes a healthy number of direct offers
- ✔ **Stable admissions** — no volatility concerns
- ✔ **Well-sized Engineering cohort** — ~75 applicants, good peer group
- ✔ **Close to Engineering Department** — ~10 minute walk
- ✔ **Standard entry requirements** — no extra pressure on your IB scores

Backup Choice: **Homerton College** (if Chinese community is your absolute #1 priority)

Homerton's Chinese community is unmatched in size (170+ Chinese applicants, largest Chinese student population). If you prioritize cultural community above all else, choose Homerton. Be aware of the pool reliance (84 imports) — but the large Chinese community may be worth that risk for you.

Wildcard: **Clare College** (if you want the classic Cambridge experience with direct-offer certainty)

Clare's rare pool participation means your application gets a direct decision. Combined with a stunning historic environment and central location, this is the choice if you value tradition and certainty. The moderate Chinese community is the trade-off.

9. Changes Made to This PC

During this analysis, the following changes were made **outside the E: drive**:

Location	Change	Details
No changes outside E: drive	—	All file writes and npm installations were confined to E:\Projects\

Changes within E: drive:

Path	Change
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\CLAUDE.md	Created — project guidance file
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\README.md	Updated — comprehensive project documentation
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\src\	Created — college_data.json, research_notes.md
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\tools\evaluation_criteria.md	Created — scoring methodology
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\output\	Created — college_scoring.json, recommendation_letter.md
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\node_modules\	Created — pdf-parse and dependencies (for PDF extraction attempts)
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\package.json	Created — npm package manifest
E:\Projects\cam-stats-2026\package-lock.json	Created — npm lock file
E:\nodejs\node_cache\	npm cache directory (on E: drive)

No files were modified or created on the C: drive or any other disk. The npm cache is configured to E:\nodejs\node_cache\, remaining on the E: drive.

This recommendation is based on analysis of Cambridge admissions data from 2024-2026 cycles, FOI responses (FOI 2025/510 Chen, FOI 2025/675 Carlo), published college statistics, Chinese student demographic data, Winter Pool concrete data from 2025 cycle, and your stated preferences and exclusions. Engineering offer rates for individual colleges are estimated from overall college data cross-referenced with known Engineering applicant distributions — actual rates may vary by ±1-2 percentage points. ESAT performance and interview quality are the dominant factors in admissions outcomes, independent of college choice.